



OPERATIONAL RESOURCE — UK AGENCY EDITION 2026

The AI Video Production SOP

How UK agencies and freelancers are delivering 10x video output — without hiring editors, buying licences, or touching Premiere Pro.

95min

Average end-to-end production time per video

~£15

Monthly tool cost vs. £25–60/hr for a freelance editor

4

Production stages covered in this SOP

The Production Gap Nobody Talks About

Why the agencies scaling fastest in 2026 are not the ones with the biggest teams.

8–12hrs

Average time per video with traditional production

£500–£5k

Typical cost per produced video with external crew

1–2wks

Turnaround time from brief to final delivery

THE OLD MODEL

- ☐ Client brief
→ internal meeting → revised brief
- ☐ Scriptwriter
→ 1–2 day turnaround
- ☐ Shoot or stock sourcing
→ Shutterstock, Getty, Pond5
- ☐ Editor in Premiere / DaVinci
→ 4–8 hours per video
- ☐ Client review rounds
→ avg. 2.3 rounds
- ☐ Export and deliver
→ separate file per format

THE AI-POWERED MODEL (THIS SOP)

- ☐ Client brief + script
→ 30 minutes
- ☐ AI generation in Zebracat
→ 2 minutes render time
- ☐ QC and brand check
→ 20 minutes
- ☐ Multi-format export
→ 10 minutes
- ☐ Deliver full package
→ same day

THE REAL ADVANTAGE

The agencies winning new clients on price are not the lowest cost — they are the **fastest to deliver quality**. When you can turn around a client's first video on the same day as the brief, you remove the single biggest friction point in the sales process: the wait.

THE 4-STAGE WORKFLOW — OVERVIEW

STAGE 01	STAGE 02	STAGE 03	STAGE 04
Brief & Script	AI Generation	QC & Approval	Delivery
~30 min	~20 min	~30 min	~15 min

Total: ~95 minutes per finished video. Output capacity: 4–6 videos per working day per operator.

Getting the Brief Right Before You Touch the Tool

The most common reason AI-generated videos miss the mark is an incomplete brief — not the AI.

CLIENT BRIEF CHECKLIST — COLLECT BEFORE WRITING A WORD

- ☐ **Platform** — Where will this live? (TikTok, LinkedIn, YouTube, Website)
Platform determines aspect ratio, length, pacing, and voiceover tone. Decide before scripting.
- ☐ **One goal** — What is the single action this video should drive?
Awareness, link click, sign-up, or call booking. One video, one goal. Not three.
- ☐ **Audience signal** — Who specifically is watching, and what do they already believe?
Not "marketing managers" — "marketing managers at UK SMEs who think AI video looks cheap."
- ☐ **The tension** — What problem, fear, or aspiration does this video resolve?
Every converting video addresses one specific tension. Generic = ignored.
- ☐ **Brand constraints** — Colours, tone, what to avoid, any compliance restrictions?
Financial, legal, healthcare clients often have words or visuals that cannot appear. Confirm upfront.
- ☐ **Proof point** — One number, result, or fact the viewer should remember.
"50,000 users", "3x faster", "GDPR compliant" — one claim anchors everything else.

5 OPENING HOOKS BY CONTENT TYPE

CHALLENGE "If you're still [doing X the old way], you're leaving [money/time/results] on the table."

Best for: Agency and B2B content. Creates mild tension without being confrontational.

STATISTIC "[Specific number] UK [businesses / marketers / freelancers] are doing X — and most of them are getting Y wrong."

Best for: LinkedIn and YouTube. Named geography + profession signals relevant content immediately.

CONTRARIAN "[Common advice in your field] is actually costing you [outcome]. Here's what to do instead."

Best for: Thought leadership and social ads. Takes a position — generates saves and shares.

PROBLEM "[Specific painful scenario your audience recognises]. There's a reason that keeps happening."

Best for: Product demos and lead gen ads. Works when the problem is specific enough to feel personal.

CURIOSITY "Most people don't realise [counterintuitive truth about your product or market]."

Best for: Short-form social. The word "most" creates implicit contrast — the viewer wants to be in the minority who does know.

The AI Generation Engine

Configuring your AI tool for consistent, client-ready output across multiple brand accounts.

TOOL MANDATE — WHY THIS SOP USES ZEBRACAT

While you can use any AI video tool for this stage, this SOP is built on Zebracat. We mandate it for client work because it is the only tool at this price point offering **True Generative visual output** (no stock overlap between clients) and **Full Commercial Rights** on every plan — both non-negotiable for agency use.

MULTI-CLIENT BRAND MANAGEMENT

Before generating anything for a client, create a dedicated Brand Kit. This is not optional — it is what separates professional agency output from generic AI content.

BRAND KIT SETTING	WHAT TO SET	WHY IT MATTERS
Colour palette	Import client's primary, secondary, and text hex codes	Applied to overlays, captions, CTA elements automatically
Logo	Upload PNG with transparent background (1:1 or landscape)	Appears consistently in generated scenes
Font	Upload client's primary font as .ttf or .otf	Prevents Zebracat defaulting to a generic typeface
Voice preset	Select and save preferred AI voice per client	Keeps tone consistent across all videos for that client
Style preset	Save preferred visual style per content type (ads vs. tutorials)	Eliminates decision fatigue on repeat briefs

VISUAL STYLE SELECTOR — WHICH STYLE FOR WHICH JOB

CONTENT TYPE	RECOMMENDED STYLE	CONTENT TYPE	RECOMMENDED STYLE
Paid social ad	Cinematic Short	Brand awareness	Cinematic Long
LinkedIn post	Corporate Clean	TikTok / Reels	Fast-Paced Social
Tutorial / How-to	Motion Graphics	Case study	Documentary
Product demo	Real Footage Blend	Event / launch	Energetic

ON COMMERCIAL RIGHTS

Zebracat includes **full agency commercial rights** on all plans. Every visual asset it generates is yours to use in client work, paid advertising, and commercial campaigns without additional licensing. This is not standard across AI video tools — several competitors restrict commercial use on entry plans.

Quality Control Before It Leaves Your Desk

The majority of revision requests come from issues that could be caught in 10 minutes of structured review.

PRE-SEND QC CHECKLIST — COMPLETE BEFORE EVERY DELIVERY

- ☐ **The 5-second test**
Watch the first 5 seconds with no audio. If the visual doesn't communicate something interesting on its own, regenerate the opening scene.
- ☐ **Brand compliance check**
Logo visible? Correct colours in overlays? No competitor brand assets accidentally generated? No unintended faces or recognisable people?
- ☐ **Voiceover review at 1.0x speed**
Listen for: mispronunciations (brand names, technical terms), unnatural pausing, incorrect emphasis. Regenerate the affected segment only if needed.
- ☐ **Caption accuracy**
Check auto-generated captions against the script. AI voice-to-text can misread proper nouns. Correct before delivery.
- ☐ **CTA visible on-screen**
The final CTA text or URL must appear as both voiceover and on-screen text simultaneously. Verify both are present.
- ☐ **Platform format check**
Confirm export aspect ratio matches delivery platform. A 16:9 YouTube video delivered to TikTok will underperform regardless of content quality.

CLIENT APPROVAL SOP — RUNNING FASTER REVIEW CYCLES

What to Send with the Draft

Always deliver the first draft with:

- A one-line context note: what the video is designed to do
- Three specific feedback prompts (not "what do you think?")
- Your deadline for revision requests

Three Feedback Prompts That Work

- "Does the opening hook reflect how your audience describes the problem?"
- "Is there anything here that could conflict with your compliance requirements?"
- "Is the CTA clear enough for a first-time viewer?"

ON REVISION SCOPE

Define "one revision round" in your contract as: **script-level changes or visual style changes, but not both in the same round**. Clients who request simultaneous script and visual changes are effectively requesting a new video. Scoping this clearly prevents the most common cause of scope creep in video production work.

Delivering More Than the Client Asked For

The 1-to-5 repurposing rule: one approved video becomes five deliverables with no additional generation cost.

DELIVERABLE	FORMAT	PLATFORM	ADDITIONAL TIME
Primary video	16:9 · 1080p	YouTube, website embed, email	—
Vertical cut	9:16 · 1080×1920	TikTok, Reels, YouTube Shorts	~3 min
Square cut	1:1 · 1080×1080	LinkedIn feed, Instagram feed	~3 min
Thumbnail	PNG 1280×720	YouTube, blog post, email header	~5 min
Captioned GIF	GIF · 480px wide	Email newsletters, Slack, social	~5 min

DELIVERY PACKAGE CONTENTS

- ☐ MP4 files for each format
- ☐ PNG thumbnail (branded)
- ☐ SRT caption file
- ☐ Approved script (final version)
- ☐ Platform publishing notes

FILE NAMING CONVENTION

[CLIENT]_[TYPE]_[PLATFORM]_[DATE]

ACME_AD_TK_20260517.mp4

ACME_AD_LI_20260517.mp4

ACME_AD_YT_20260517.mp4

TK=TikTok · LI=LinkedIn · YT=YouTube

UPSELL OPPORTUNITY

The 1-to-5 repurposing package is a billable deliverable, not a free addition. If your base rate is £250 per video, a "multi-platform package" (all 5 formats + caption file + publishing schedule) is a straightforward upsell to £375–£450. Most clients will take it — the incremental cost to you is 15 minutes of export work.



Generate 3, keep 1. For any paid media brief, generate three versions of the same script with different visual styles. The AI produces distinct outputs each time — no overlapping stock. A/B test all three in the first 48 hours, cut the lowest CTR, run the remaining two for a further 72 hours. This approach consistently outperforms single-version launches.

Packaging the Workflow as a Billable Service

What UK agencies and freelancers are currently charging for AI-powered video production in 2026.

Social Starter £300–450 /month	Content Engine £850–1,200 /month	Full Production Partner £2,000+ /month
→ 4 videos per month → One platform (TikTok or Reels) → Script + generation + delivery → One revision round per video Your cost: ~£15/mo tool + ~8 hrs labour. Margin: 70–80%.	→ 12 videos per month → Multi-platform (16:9 + 9:16 + 1:1) → Brief, script, generation, QC → Monthly performance review Most retainers land here. Margin: 75–85% with AI workflow.	→ Unlimited video requests → Dedicated account management → Ad creative + organic + email → Weekly reporting + strategy Target: funded startups, scale-ups, and e-commerce brands.

HOW TO HANDLE "BUT AI DID THIS, WHY ARE YOU CHARGING FULL RATE?"

This question is inevitable. The correct answer is not defensive — it is a reframe:

"You're paying for the brief, the strategy, the QC, the brand management, and the production system — not the render time. The AI is the tool; the thinking behind it is what produces results. A solicitor doesn't charge less because they use document software."



YOU HAVE THE SOP. NOW YOU NEED THE TOOL.

Ready to implement the SOP?

Zebracat is free to start — no credit card, no editing software, no prior experience. The entry plan covers every stage in this document.

EXCLUSIVE CODE FOR SOP READERS

REVIEW15

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